

Lesson 3

Agreeing and Disagreeing



Warm-Up

Motivation Questions:

1. Why is it important to express agreement and disagreement effectively in a business setting?
2. Can you think of a situation where agreeing or disagreeing politely made a difference in a business meeting?
3. How do cultural differences impact the way we agree or disagree in business?





Role-Play

Read the following dialogue.

Person A: I believe we should invest more in digital marketing. With the increasing number of people online, it's crucial to enhance our online presence and reach a wider audience. Digital marketing can help us target specific demographics and measure our results more effectively.

Person B: I see your point, and digital marketing is indeed important. **However**, I think we should focus on improving our product first. If our product isn't up to par, no amount of marketing will convince customers to buy it. Enhancing our product will ensure that we have a strong foundation to build our marketing efforts on.

Person A: **That's a valid argument.** Improving our product is essential for long-term success. **But, I believe that** investing in digital marketing can also provide immediate benefits. It can help us gather customer feedback and understand market trends, which can inform our product development.

Person B: I understand where you're coming from. Gathering customer feedback through marketing efforts can be valuable. However, if we allocate too many resources to marketing without a solid product, we might end up with dissatisfied customers. A balanced approach might be the best way forward.

Person A: I agree that a balanced approach is important. **Perhaps** we can allocate a portion of our budget to digital marketing while simultaneously working on product improvements. This way, we can start building our online presence and gather insights while ensuring our product meets customer expectations.

Person B: That **sounds like a reasonable plan.** By investing in both areas, we can ensure that our product is strong and our marketing efforts are effective. Let's discuss how we can divide our resources to achieve this balance.

Role-play Analysis

Answer the following questions:

1. What expressions did Person B use to disagree politely?
2. How did Person A express their agreement?
3. What could Person A say to acknowledge Person B's point before restating their own opinion?

Discussion

1. How can you disagree with someone without causing offense?
2. What are some phrases you can use to show partial agreement?
3. How does the tone of voice affect the perception of agreement or disagreement?



Vocabulary

Practice pronouncing the following words / phrases

- Agree /ə'griː/
- Disagree /ˌdɪsə'griː/
- Point /pɔɪnt/
- Perspective /pər'spektɪv/
- Acknowledge /ək'nɒlɪdʒ/
- Respectfully /rɪ'spektfəli/
- Partially agree /pɑːʃəli ə'griː/
- Strongly agree /'strɒŋli ə'griː/
- See it differently /siː ɪt 'dɪfərəntli/
- Express doubt /ɪk'spres 'daʊt/
- Support /sə'pɔːt/



Practice

Express your opinion

- Work in pairs.
- Each pair is given a statement.
- You must express your views on the statement using the target language.
- After 1–2 minutes, rotate to a new statement.

Statements:

1. *It's better to live in the countryside than the city.*
2. *Smartphones are making people less social.*
3. *It's better to have one best friend than many friends.*
4. *People should work only four days a week.*
5. *AI will replace most jobs in the future.*



Production

Activity 1: Debate

Topic: "Remote work is more productive than office work."

Instructions:

1. **Participants:** Work in pairs/groups. One side will argue in favor of the statement (Pro), and the other will argue against it (Con).
2. **Preparation:** Each side should spend 05 minutes preparing their arguments. They should consider various aspects such as productivity, work-life balance, communication, and company culture.

3. Debate Structure:

- **Opening Statements:** Each side presents their main arguments (02 - 03 minutes per side).
- **Rebuttals:** Each side responds to the opposing arguments (02 - 03 minutes per side).
- **Open Debate:** Participants engage in a back-and-forth discussion, using phrases for agreeing and disagreeing (05 minutes).
- **Closing Statements:** Each side summarizes their key points and makes a final appeal (02 - 03 minutes per side).

Activity 2: Giving Opinions through a Case Study

1. Preparation:

- Work in small groups.
- Each group reads the case study and discusses the potential strategies.
- Each participant prepares their opinion on the best strategy to address the decline in sales.

2. Meeting Simulation:

- One participant acts as the meeting facilitator.
- Each participant takes turns presenting their opinion on the best strategy (02 - 03 minutes per person).
- After each presentation, other participants can ask questions or provide feedback (01 - 02 minutes per person).

3. Group Discussion:

- The facilitator leads a group discussion to compare and contrast the different opinions.
- Participants use phrases for agreeing and disagreeing to engage in a constructive debate.
- Afterwards, they will present their findings to the class.

Case Study A:

Background: *Company X is a mid-sized technology firm specializing in consumer electronics. Over the past year, the company has experienced a decline in sales for its flagship product, the SmartWidget. The management team is concerned about this trend and is considering several strategies to address the issue.*

Problem Statement: *Sales of the SmartWidget have decreased by 15% over the past year. Customer feedback indicates that while the product is generally well-received, there are concerns about its price, features, and the effectiveness of the current marketing campaign.*

Case Study B:

Background: *Company Y is a well-established retail chain specializing in home goods and furniture. Recently, the company has noticed a significant drop in foot traffic to its physical stores, while online sales have seen a moderate increase. The management team is exploring ways to adapt to these changing consumer behaviors and boost overall sales.*

Problem Statement: *Foot traffic to Company Y's physical stores has decreased by 20% over the past six months. Although online sales have increased by 10%, the overall revenue is still declining. The company needs to find a strategy to address this shift and improve its financial performance.*



Key Vocabulary

Target Phrases	Use	Example
I completely agree.	To express full agreement with someone's statement or opinion.	<i>I completely agree with your suggestion to implement a new marketing strategy.</i>
I see your point, but...	To acknowledge someone's opinion while introducing a differing opinion or concern.	<i>I see your point, but I think we should consider the budget constraints before making a decision.</i>
I have a slightly different view.	To politely introduce a differing opinion or perspective.	<i>I have a slightly different view on this matter; I believe we should focus on customer feedback first.</i>
I completely agree with you.	To express full agreement with someone's statement or opinion, emphasizing the person you agree with.	<i>I completely agree with you that we need to prioritize employee training.</i>
I see what you mean but...	To acknowledge someone's opinion while introducing a differing opinion or concern.	<i>I see what you mean, but we need to ensure that the new policy aligns with our company's values.</i>
I'd like to offer a different perspective.	To introduce an alternative opinion or viewpoint in a respectful manner.	<i>I'd like to offer a different perspective on this issue; perhaps we should explore more sustainable options.</i>



Wrap-Up

"The art of conversation lies in listening." – Malcolm Forbes